

Your Autistic Classmate / Friend

For teenage peers, friends & classmates — getting along with an autistic **teenager** (roughly ages 12–18).

The one idea

Autism, through **monotropism**, means a friend's attention locks into a few deep, intense "tunnels." Secondary school is a social minefield, and many autistic teens are masking all day and **running on empty** — this is also the age anxiety, depression and burnout peak. They might take things literally, need predictability, avoid the loud stuff, and communicate best in writing or around a shared interest. Being the friend who doesn't make them perform "normal" can be genuinely life-saving — autistic teens with even one good friend do far better.

What you may see — and what's really going on

You may see...	What's often happening
Intense about one interest; not into small talk	A passion — and the easiest way to connect
Cancels, goes quiet, or "ghosts" for a bit	Overloaded or burning out — not about you
Takes things literally; misses sarcasm or hints	Literal communication — say what you mean
Avoids the canteen, assemblies, parties	Sensory/social overload — genuinely painful
Blunt or "too honest"	Literal and direct — usually well-meant

Try this

- **Hang out around the interest** — it's where they're most themselves.
- **Keep it low-pressure and flexible** — text, one-to-one, no "everyone must come" demands.
- **Say what you mean**; check in literally ("you okay?") and mean it.
- **Offer a quiet alternative** to the loud stuff — a walk, a game, side-by-side.
- **Be the safe friend** — the one they can unmask around without judgement.

Avoid this

- Sarcasm, teasing, or pressuring them into loud social events.
- Taking a cancellation or silence personally.
- "Helping" by pushing them to be "more social."

When to get more support

If your friend talks about feeling hopeless, exhausted beyond normal, or not wanting to be here, **tell a trusted adult** — autistic teens are at higher risk, and one friend speaking up can save a life. Being a steady, accepting friend is powerful protection.

If your friend is a girl or marginalised gender

Autistic girls and marginalised genders mask intensely and are often missed; a "quietly fine, anxious perfectionist" may be struggling more than they show. Take their overload seriously.

About this guide

*AI-assisted, derived from this project's research drafts — the **Family guide** (Parts 4 & 6), **Growing Up Monotropic** (Part 1) and the **Monotropism** brief. Uses identity-first language. **Informational — not a diagnostic tool.** Fit it to the individual.*

Key sources. Murray, Lesser & Lawson (2005); Murray, F. (2023); Dwyer (2025); Milton (2012, double empathy); Raymaker et al. (2020, burnout); Bradley et al. (2021, camouflaging). Full citations are in the source drafts.